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ENIGMATIC WRITINGS: KARL MARX'S *THE CIVIL WAR IN FRANCE* AND THE PARIS COMMUNE OF 1871

R. Thomas

The idea that the General Council of the First International should publish a defence of the Paris Commune originated from a proposal made by Karl Marx at the council meeting of 28 March 1871. The surviving minutes do not record any substantive discussion on the matter which was agreed unanimously.[1] Marx was unable to complete the address for several weeks. *The Civil War in France* was eventually read to the General Council on 30 May and it was published by Edward Truelove, London, on 13 June. The completion of the text had been delayed partly because the General Council wished to be better informed on what was occurring in Paris and partly because Marx was unable to attend the meetings in May, or to work consistently on the address. It would appear that he was suffering from acute depression and that these personal problems were compounded by the gloomy anticipation of the collapse of the Paris Commune and the profound effects these events would have for the First International.[2] Marx moved from the context of writing an address to the people of Paris supporting their revolution to the realization that the Commune was doomed,

[1] *Documents of the First International, 1870–1871*, Institute of Marxism-Leninism of the CC, CPSU (Moscow, 1966 and London, 1976), p. 166. The minutes record that K. Marx proposed that an address be issued to the people of Paris.

[2] Letter of Marx's daughter, Jenny Marx, 18 April 1871: 'Mohr (Marx) and he (Engels) go out for long walks together, whenever Mohr's health permits it . . . The present state of things causes our dear Mohr intense suffering and no doubt is one of the chief causes of his illness. A great number of friends are in the Commune. Some of them have already fallen victims to the butchers of Versailles.' *Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels Writings on the Paris Commune*, ed. H. Draper (New York and London, 1971), p. 222. At the General Council meeting of 23 May Marx stated that he had been ill, *Documents of the First International 1870–1871*, p. 200. In a letter written by Engels to Ludwig Kugelmann dated 28 April, Engels referred only to Marx's physical condition; to a troublesome cough which prevented him from sleeping, although he added 'that there can be no speedy cure for a cronic illness that, to my knowledge, has been more or less permanent for the last 26 years'. *Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, Collected Works* (hereafter *Collected Works*), Vol. 44, ed. L. Golman, V. Pospelova and T. Yeremeyeva (London, 1989), Letters July 1870–December 1873, p. 143.

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a perception that was intensified by a dread of what was happening and going to happen in a war where Communard prisoners were shot, and where a prejudicial press obscured the acts of the Commune. He found himself finally writing the Commune's obituary in the form of a defence.

It has been suggested by several authors that *The Civil War in France* does not represent Marx's real views about the Paris Commune and that his later critical observations expressed in a letter of 22 February 1881 written to the Dutch socialist F. Domela-Nieuwenhuis are a more frank and accurate evaluation of the Commune.[3] One author in particular, Shlomo Avineri, has suggested that Marx sought to distort the portrayal of the working class and middle classes making the Paris Commune more proletarian than it actually was. The author adds that these social themes can be gleaned from several of Marx's more explicit admissions written in the first draft of the address.[4] This theme of Marx's considered misrepresentation has merged with more widespread revisionist comments about Marxian legends and a mythological Commune. This mythology can be construed in a negative manner, as with Robert Tombs, who infers that Marx was apparently 'less than wholly convinced by his own rhetoric', and had sought to mislead the public with a polemical work that reaffirmed the Commune as an unlikely '. . . glorious harbinger of a new society . . . whose martyrs were to rest for ever enshrined in the great heart of the working class'.[5] A more positive representation has been given by Roger Magraw who suggests that the address was 'a bold attempt to salvage a utilizable heroic myth from the wreckage'.[6] It might be surmised that Marx had realized that the Paris Commune was a predictable disaster by early April for he had already forewarned various French socialists of the risks involved in

[3] 'Perhaps you will refer me to the Paris Commune; but apart from the fact that this was merely the rising of a city under exceptional conditions, the majority of the Commune was in no wise socialist, nor could it be.' *Collected Works*, Vol. 46, ed. V. Smirnova (London, 1992), K. Marx to Ferdinand Domela-Nieuwenhuis, p. 66. Both Roger Magraw in *A History of the French Working Class: Volume 1 The Age of Artisan Revolution 1815–1871* (Oxford, 1992), p. 262, and *The Paris Commune of 1871: The View from the Left*, ed. Eugene Schulkind (London, 1972), pp. 52–3, 200–1 and 244, and Eugene Schulkind in *The Paris Commune of 1871* (London, 1972), p. 35, would appear to share this view, as does Paul Thomas, *Alien Politics. Marxist State Theory Retrieved* (London, 1994), p. 106.

[4] Shlomo Avineri, *The Social and Political Thought of Karl Marx* (Cambridge, 1968), pp. 247–9.

[5] R. Tombs, *The War Against Paris 1871* (Cambridge, 1981), p. 193. Edward S. Mason notoriously claimed that 'the Marxian history of the Commune is from beginning to end, almost pure myth'. Edward S. Mason, *The Paris Commune An Episode in the History of the Socialist Movement* (New York, 1930; reprinted New York, 1967), p. 320.

[6] Magraw, *The Age of Artisan Revolution 1815–1871*, p. 262.

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taking the revolutionary way in his Second Address of 9 September 1870.[7] This point is most frequently raised by those authors who wish to imply that Marx always had a cautious attitude to the Commune. This reticence was hidden because of his public obligation to defend the Paris Commune. These themes have encouraged some authors to insist upon an unhelpful distinction between a 'public' and a 'private' Marx. Finally the core passages of *The Civil War in France* are represented as a projection of the potentialities of the Commune into the future. Such views are most commonly reproduced by authors who are specialists in Marxian social theory and political philosophy. Those writers who possess a detailed knowledge of the Paris Commune remain more circumspect and appreciative of the qualities of *The Civil War in France*.[8]

If Karl Marx had a hidden agenda in April and May of 1871 it would appear that the more likely subject was the nature of the French state during the transition to socialism. Such a theme would have been intentionally opposed to the views of Bakunin and his allies in the Jura Federation and the First International, who believed that socialism and the state were fundamentally incompatible.[9] Throughout his long career as a prolific journalist and political commentator Marx had repeatedly returned to the problematic of the state. As Bob Jessop has indicated, Marx's writings on the state occur as a sequence of distinct clusters with little evolving continuity between the perspectives outlined in the *Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Law* (1843), *The Communist Manifesto* (1847–8) and *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852).[10] Marx did not attempt to systematize his diverse analyses of the state. Several commentators have nevertheless sought to stress Marx's commitment to his earlier views of the state expressed in the early 1840s or 1847 to 1848 and they have consequently devalued or even ignored the significance of *The Civil War*

[7] 'The General Council of the International Working Men's Association on the War: Second Address', *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, ed. T. Yeremeyeva and V. Kunina (London, 1986), p. 269.

[8] Shlomo Avineri's Chapter 8, 'The New Society, the Paris Commune: the Necessary Failure', *The Social and Political Thought of Karl Marx*, pp. 239–49, has been widely influential, as for example with Richard Applebaum, *Karl Marx* (London, 1988), p. 136. An earlier essay written by a writer who had a detailed knowledge of the Paris Commune is J. Rougerie, 'Karl Marx, L'Etat et La Commune', *Preuves*, No. 212 (1968), pp. 34–42; and No. 213 (1968), pp. 45–56. For a trenchant defence of Marx's views on the Paris Commune see Monty Johnstone, 'The Commune and Marx's Conception of the Dictatorship of the Proletariat and the Role of the Party', in *Images of the Commune*, ed. J. Leith (Montreal and London, 1978), pp. 201–24.

[9] Alvin Gouldner, 'Marx's Last Battle: Bakunin and the First Inernational', *Theory and Society* (1982), pp. 853–84; and Paul Thompson, *Marx and the Anarchists* (London, 1980).

[10] B. Jessop, 'Marx and Engels on the State', in *Politics, Ideology and the State*, ed. Sally Hibbin (London, 1978), p. 40; and B. Jessop, *The Capitalist State* (Oxford, 1982), p. 218. Michael Levin has also argued that Marx never attempted to establish a comprehensive organized theory of the state, M. Levin, 'Marx and Engels on the Generalized Class State', *History of Political Thought*, Vol. 6 (1985), pp. 433–53.

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in France.[11] Such views need to be corrected by accepting that the immediate historical context is highly influential in the production of the text. Bob Jessop in particular has placed an emphasis upon discontinuity in Marx's writings on the state in order to challenge the earlier Marxian tradition which made excessive claims for the consistency and coherence of Marx's thought. Marx did not construct an essentialist view of the state. Instead there were distinct phases of diverse writings which included a naïve representation of an instrumental state, *The Manifesto*, the influential parasitic Bonapartist state, *The Eighteenth Brumaire* and the workers' state, *The Civil War in France*. This approach gives a degree of autonomy to the text of *The Civil War in France* and does not succumb to the forms of over-determination exercised by those authors who insist on the consistency of Marx's views between 1870 and 1881.

In assessing the qualitative nature of the writing in *The Civil War in France* it is difficult to ascertain whether there was a significant weakening of Marx's intellectual powers in comparison with the pamphleteering style of *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*. The clarity and brilliance of some of the metaphors of the latter work are not repeated in *The Civil War*, whose text in Part One contains elements of gossip, ridicule, sarcasm and abuse directed at the Commune's enemies: Jules Favre, Ernest Picard, Jules Ferry and Adolphe Thiers. Several past commentators have admired these aspects of Marx's pamphleteering style, in particular Charles Longuet, Marx's son-in-law and the editor of the French edition of *The Civil War* (1900–1), who stated that these eloquent and powerful passages were a model of powerful invective.[12] If there is a paucity of literary invention in the address one also needs to understand the prescribed circumstances in which Marx wrote *The Civil War in France*. He had a most limited access to information about the Commune. Marx collected material from the English and French press reports about the Commune. This material filled twenty-four pages of a copy book.[13] These press cuttings commence with extracts from *The Daily News* and *La Situation* for 18 March and

[11] As for example with Robert Meister, *Political Identity: Thinking Through Marx* (Oxford, 1990); *The Cambridge Companion to Marx*, ed. Terrell Carver (Cambridge, 1991); and Alan Carter, *Marx: A Radical Critique* (Brighton, 1988).

[12] *Karl Marx La Commune de Paris*, ed. Charles Longuet (Paris, 1901), Preface, p. XI. More recently the anonymous editor of *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, has written: 'With biting sarcasm he exposed the leaders of the Versailles counter-revolutionary government, the instigators and organisers of the savage reprisals against the Paris Workers.' Preface, p. xxii.

[13] *La Guerre Civile en France, 1871*, Editions Nouvelle Accompagnee des Travaux Preparatoires de Marx (Paris, 1953; reprints, 1968 and 1973). The press extracts are not to be found in the Peking edition of *The Civil War in France* (Peking, 1966), or the Soviet collection *Marx and Engels on the Paris Commune* (Moscow, 1971), *Karl Marx and Friedrick Engels Writings on the Paris Commune*, ed. Draper, nor *Collected Works*, Vol. 22. Edward Mason made the erroneous statement that 'He [Marx] read every word of the Journal Officiel', Mason, *The Paris Commune*, p. 309.

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conclude with two lines from *La Situation* for 30 April and 1 May. The Versailles blockade of Paris and the ensuing bitterness of the war produced a zone of exclusion which made it most difficult for letters and newspapers to leave the beleaguered city. Circumstantially one could say this possibly precluded Marx from having access to the more detailed material associated with the discussion about co-operative workshops, more especially the employment schemes organized by the Association of Women for the Defence of Paris and Aid to the Wounded which were outlined in early May.[14]

It is noticeable that most of the contemporary English press followed *The Times* in concentrating their respective reports on the military situation; articles on Communard socialism and working class activity were only occasionally printed.[15] *The Times* did, however, publish a detailed report on the events in Montmartre and Belleville between eight thirty in the morning and mid-day on 18 March, which represented their account of how the insurrection broke out. Yet this interesting narration was relegated to page nine of the 20 March edition. Subsequently the editors were considerably less adventurous, although an edited version of the Commune Declaration to the French People was published on 21 April, with a further commentary on the programme in the 22 April editions. Only one substantive article on the working class was published, that of 6 May, which was concerned with the clubs. In this article the journalist stressed the grubbiness and squalor of the audience of the women's club on the Boulevard d'Italie whose meeting was held 'in a filthy room reeking with evil odour'. The author's attention was held by the leading speaker 'a fine looking woman with streaming black hair and flashing eyes'. Although he conceded that she 'looked very handsome, and might have sat for the portrait of one of those heroines of the first revolution', he added in a condescending manner 'there was that in her eye which made me think as I looked at her that I should

[14] The activities of the Association of Women for the Defence of Paris and Aid to the Wounded have been throughly researched by Eugene Schulkind in 'Socialist Women during the 1871 Paris Commune', *Past and Present*, No. 106 (1985), pp. 124–63 and *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. Schulkind, pp. 171–8. The initial Union address, 'A Call to the Women Citizens of Paris', was published in the *Journal Officiel*, 11 April 1871, while their request to the Commune was published in the *Journal Officiel* on 14 April 1871. The letter from the Union to the Commission of Labour and Exchange is dated by E. Schulkind, late April or early May. This document contains an analysis of women's work and a proposed organizational plan. The Central Committee of the Union produced a declaration which was printed in the *Journal Officiel* on 6 May.

[15] For a lively discussion of those English writers who were prepared to defend the Paris Commune in Britain see *The English Defence of the Commune* (1871), ed. Royden Harrison (London, 1971). *The Times* used Reuters telegrams and had its own reporter in Paris. On 26 April, after the blockade of the Northern Railway, it used material from Brussels. For the French Press see Georges Tersen, 'L'Opinion Publique et La Commune de Paris, 1871–1879' (Paris 1952). Diplome d'Etudes Superieurs (University of Sussex Microfilm).

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not like to be her husband'. In the remaining sections of his account socialist feminists succumbed to fantasies about fighting on the barricades and using petroleum. These obsessive women ranted and railed against priests, some mimicked the ritual of the mass, while others endlessly grumbled about cowardly and exploitative men![16]

The press extracts collected by Marx are not nearly so lurid as this piece of reporting. The overwhelming attitude of the transfixed English press to the Paris Commune was one of hostility and bewilderment. After the success of the Communard elections one or two papers adopted the stance of reserved neutrality. Marx turned most frequently to reports published in the Liberal *Daily News*. There are twenty seven press extracts from this newspaper; the larger pieces are from 20, 23, 25, 30 and 31 March, and during 21, 24 and 25 April, the final reports of 26, 28 and 29 April are much briefer. This material was supported by cuttings from the Tory *Standard* (eight extracts), *The Irishman* (two extracts) and *The Observer* (one extract). He also used the *Daily Telegraph* for which there were five cuttings. The longest piece from that newspaper dealt with the demonstration by the supporters of the Party of Order and their dispersal by the National Guard in the Place de Vendome. The General Council of the First International subsequently pointed out that *The Daily Telegraph*'s Parisian correspondent, Mr Robert Reid, had his telegraphic despatches falsified by the editorial staff of that newspaper.[17] The other extracts for 3 April and 5 April were minimalist, while that of 6 April, which dealt with the Commune's protests at the Versailles' brutal treatment of Communard prisoners and wounded soldiers, also contained the news of the arrest of the Archbishop of Paris for plotting against the Commune.

The French newspapers from Versailles and Paris which were used by Marx included the *Petit Journal* which was banned by the Commune on 5 May, *La Cloche*, *Le Figaro*, *Le National*, *Le Rappel*, *La Liberté*, which was published in Brussels, as well as some Communard papers, including Felix Pyat's *Le Vengeur*. However, Marx's collections of newspaper extracts did not contain any cuttings from the two most popular Commune papers, *Le Père Duchêne* and *Le Cri du Peuple*, nor were there any pieces from the *Journal Officiel*. Marx mostly used *La Situation* (seventeen extracts), and *Le Rappel* (eight extracts),

[16] *The Times*, 6 May 1871; similar prejudicial attitudes towards women are expressed in the book by Paul Fontoulieu, *Les Eglises sous La Commune* (Paris, 1873). This author mentions womens' meetings in the churches of St Eustace, St Pierre, Montmartre, St Eloi, Rue de Reuilly, St Jacques de Haut-Pas, Notre Dame de La Croix, Ménilmontant, St Ambroise, XIII arrondissement, St Nicholas-des-Champs, III arrondissement, St Lambert, St Germain L'Auxerrois, St Marguerite, Rue Saint Bernard, Saint Pierre, Montrouge, St Leu, St Trinity, and St Michel, Batignolles.

[17] Minutes of the General Council Meeting of 4 July 1871, *Documents of the First International 1870–1871*: '*The Telegraph* had suppressed part of his [Reid] letters and telegrams he had sent because they gave truthful facts favourable to the Commune', pp. 228–9

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although the latter was superseded after 7 April by Henri Rochefort's *Le Mot d'Ordre*, for which there are eight extracts between 20 and 29 April.

The material contained in these newspaper clippings is a melange of telegrams and pieces of fragmentary reporting from Paris and Versailles correspondents. Those from March are initially concerned with the situation in Montmartre, the activities of the Versailles government and the mood amongst the populace of Paris. There is some reference to Communard posters, statements by Flourens and Blanqui, and an interesting cluster of responses to the uprising of 18 March. *The Daily News* of 20 March gave an account of the events in the early hours, while *La Cloche* of 21 March gave an extract from the proclamation of the Central Committee of the National Guard on 19 March. The response to the Parisian situation at the National Assembly is also well represented in these press extracts, as well as the clash between the Mayors, Admiral Saisset, the Versailles nominated commander of the National Guard, and the Central Committee of the National Guard, over their respective powers and legitimacy (*Le Rappel*, 25 March). The proclamation of the Commune and the Versailles response to this is widely reported. In general the material is selective since it is primarily concerned with troop movements, as with *Le Mot d'Ordre* of 24 April , and details of the savage fighting. The efforts of the League of the Republican Union to mediate between Thiers's government and the Commune gets a mention, as do the efforts of the Freemasons (*Le Mot D'Ordre*, 25 April). The social question is briefly alluded to in *L'Avant Garde* of 22 April, which refers to a meeting called by the mechanics' trade union to discuss social emancipation and the associational project, and notes that the Commune abolished night work for bakers on 20 April. Finally Courbet's federation of artists and the decision to demolish the Vendome column are briefly referred to in *La Situation*, 23 and 24 April. In general it can be accepted that Marx would have been unable to glean much appropriate material for his defence of the Paris Commune from these sources since they are so fragmentary, while they remain preponderantly concerned with the fortunes of war. However, embedded in these cuttings is the 19 April declaration of the Commune, *The Daily News*, 21 April, which constituted the basis of Marx's detailed commentary upon the institutional heart of the Commune.

Marx had other sources of information on the Commune, for in a letter to E.S. Beesly written on 12 June 1871 he stated that 'my relations with the Commune were maintained through a German merchant who travelled between Paris and London all the year round'.[18] This emissary and possibly others

[18] Letter of Karl Marx to Spencer Beesly, 12 June 1871, *Collected Works*, Vol. 44, pp. 150–2: p. 150 — 'A woman friend (Ann Jaclard) will be going to Paris in three or four days. I am giving her regular passports for some members of the Commune who are still hiding in Paris.'; p.151 — 'My relations with the Commune were maintained through a German merchant [N. Eilau] who travels on business between Paris and London all the year round.'

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brought letters from Paris from prominent Communards. The socialist Leo Frankel, appointed head of the influential Commission of Labour and Exchange, wrote to Marx on 10 March asking for his advice on social reforms.[19] Another letter was written by Elizabeth Dmetrieff, secretary of the Association of Women for the Defence of Paris and Aid to the Wounded, on 26 April. It was addressed to Mr Jung, a Swiss watchmaker living in London who was a member of the General Council. The letter was passed on to Marx in his capacity of general secretary. Dmetrieff begins by writing: 'It is impossible to send letters by the post service since communications are severed and everything falls into the hands of the Versailles.'[20] Marx himself wrote a letter to Frankel and Varlin as late as 13 May. These letters between Marx and members of the First International were considerably more frank and critical than anything which was to appear in the address. Both Marx and his wife Jenny make very specific criticisms of Communard politicians, in particular Felix Pyat and other 'interfering journalists', naming Paschal Grousset and Pierre Vesinier. The detail that is revealed in the First Draft especially, but also the printed address, shows that Marx was more fully informed about what was occurring in Paris than is suggested by the information contained in the press cuttings. Yet it remains clear that this source material did wither away in early May, and this meant that a lot of the interpretative weight of the address was placed on the Commune's declaration of 19 April.[21]

Turning to the text of *The Civil War in France* it can be readily acknowledged that the heart of the pamphlet, Part Three, is concerned with the institutional basis of the Paris Commune. There are two significant themes here. There is the actuality of the Commune text and the situation in Paris, and the degree to which Marx remains faithful to the wording and ideas of the proclamation and what he understood to be occurring in Paris. There is also the theme, briefly alluded to earlier, of the nature of the state in the process of the transition to socialism. The second theme would involve Marx in a confrontation with some of the revolutionary socialists in the First International, for Bakunin and his supporters in Italy and the Jura clearly believed that the state ought to be abolished. Marx responded to this critique by stressing the idea that 'the greatest social measure of the Commune was its own working existence'.[22]

[19] Letter of Frankel, 30 March, *Lettres des Communards et des Militants de la Première International à Marx, Engels, et Autres Dans Les Journées de La Commune de Paris en 1871*, ed. J. Rocher (Paris, 1934); also *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. Schulkind, pp. 117–18.

[20] Letter of Elizabeth Dmetrieff to Jung/Marx, 26 April, *Lettres des Communards et des Militants de la Première International*, ed. Rocher, pp. 36–7.

[21] 'Declaration to the People of France', *The Communards of Paris*, ed. S. Edwards (London, 1973) (hereafter 'Declaration to the People'), pp. 81–3.

[22] In his First Draft Marx wrote: 'Whatever the merits of the single measures of the Commune, its greatest measure was its own organisation, extemporised with the foreign enemy at one door, and the class enemy at the other, providing by its life its vitality,

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The Commune was in Marx's opinion the 'direct antithesis to the Empire' because it swept away the highly centralized executive and state bureaucracy, and with it the earlier forms of state machinery which had evolved with the First Empire and the July Monarchy. This process of abolition would also reinvigorate civil society. In a letter to Dr Kugelmann of 12 April Marx had written:

> If you look at the last chapter of my *Eighteenth Brumaire*, you will find that I declare that the next attempt of the French Revolution will no longer be, as before, to transfer the bureaucratic-military machine from one hand to another, but to smash it, and this is the precondition for every people's revolution on the Continent.[23]

This theme was emphasized in *The Civil War in France* where Marx wrote: 'But the working class cannot simply lay hold of the ready made state machinery, and wield it for its own purposes.'[24] The Paris Commune had come to represent several inter-related themes. Firstly it was the conquest of political power by the working class. Secondly the existence of this workers' state signified that the road to socialism was to be through a new and unprecedented democratic state, which was 'the political form at last discovered under which to work out the economic emancipation of labour'.[25] Marx was able to claim that he had anticipated the Commune and had recognized the need for the workers to reconstitute a new form of state which broke with older inherited forms of state power. The actuality of the Paris Commune confirmed what form the new state should take, thereby refuting those revolutionary socialists who thought that the state and socialism were incompatible. This emphasis upon the Commune being the direct antithesis to the Second Empire was a considered response to those Liberal commentators who perceived the Commune to be merely a form of municipal government.

The central features of Marx's mediation of the Commune are well supported by the statements made by Communards during the Paris Commune.

> Since the working class now holds political power, let it keep that power until it has — through universal and specialized education as well as through the organization of labour — completely emancipated itself, and fused all social classes into a single class of fraternal producers.[26]

> The Communal Revolution, begun by popular initiative on the 18th of March, inaugurated a new era of experimental, positive and scientific politics.

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confirming its thesis by its action.' *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, p. 339. Also: 'The greatest measure of the Commune is its own existence, working, acting under circumstances of unheard of difficulty!' *Ibid.*, p. 499.

[23] K. Marx to Ludwig Kugelmann, *Collected Works*, Vol. 44, pp. 131–2.

[24] 'The Civil War in France', *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, p. 328.

[25] *Ibid.*, pp. 334–5.

[26] Mirabeau, *L'Affranchi*, No. 2 (3 April 1871).

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> It marks the end of the old governmental and clerical world, of militarism, of bureaucracy, of exploitation, of jobbing in monopolies, of privileges to which the proletariat owes its slavery and the country its misfortunes and disasters.[27]

> The error of preceding governments must not be continued, that is to say there must not be a simple substitution of workers in the places occupied previously by the bourgeoisie . . . It is necessary to overthrow the old governmental edifice completely in order to reconstruct it according to a new plan based upon principles of justice and science.[28]

> The Revolution that has just occurred was so unexpected and so decisive that the professional politicians have understood nothing about its significance and have interpreted it only as a spontaneous outburst without implications or aims. Others have persuaded themselves of the notion that this revolution is simply a demand for what they call municipal franchise.
>
> The People, however, are not blinded by this governmental fiction, or by so-called parliamentary representation. In proclaiming the Commune they have unequivocally proclaimed . . . that it will ultimately . . . achieve the creation of a new social order, of equality, of solidarity and of freedom.[29]

Although the nuances in these passages remain distinct the general focus is clear for there is an accord between the statements by these Communard socialists and the position represented by Marx with regard to the state and the working class in *The Civil War In France*.

It is in this section of *The Civil War in France* where Marx outlines the specific features of the Paris Commune that one can see mostly clearly the influence of the 19 April Proclamation To the People of France. He begins by explaining that the Commune's councillors were elected by universal manhood suffrage and represented the particular wards throughout Paris. Marx acknowledged the influence of the Jacobin concept of the 'mandat impératif' by stating that the councillors 'were responsible and revocable at short terms'. [30] He then states that the majority of the Commune's members were 'naturally working class men, or acknowledged representatives of the working class'.[31] It is well known that there were various diverse political groups who sponsored candidates in the Commune's election and these included an alliance of clubs, a group of socialist journalists, as well as the more well-known Jacobins, Blanquists

[27] 'Declaration to the People', pp. 81–83.

[28] A. Vermorel, *L.'Ami du Peuple*, No. 2 (24 April 1871).

[29] 'Proposal for the Organisation of Producer Co–operatives for Women', mid May 1871, *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. E. Schulkind, pp. 178–80.

[30] For the 'mandat impératif' see M. Allner, 'Les Communeaux Jacobins: Heritage Ideolique et Exercise du Pouvoir Revolutionnaire', *Le Mouvement Sociale*, No. 117 (1981), pp.77–99; and in more detail M. Allner, 'Les Jacobins dans La Commune de 1871' (PhD thesis, University of Paris VII, 1976).

[31] 'The Civil War in France', p. 331.

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and members of the First International.[32] The majority of the Commune members were socialist intellectuals, journalists and activists, although an unprecedented number of working-class men were elected. As Marx relates, the first act of the Commune had been to abolish the standing army; its place was taken by the National Guard. Other recognizable features of the institutional power of the Second Empire were dismantled. The Church and State were separated and the Church's place in educational institutions was ended. The Police's political role was abolished and they became accountable to the elected Commune. More controversially Marx extended the principle of electoral accountability to senior public civil servants, magistrates and judges. Marx was clearly alert to the left-wing critique that the Church and the judiciary were the main ideological instruments of the repressive Second Empire and by implication the capitalist state. In his scheme of things these institutions would have to be divested of their powers, or democratized as with the case of the judiciary and the police. Thus in this working model the principle of electoral accountability flowed from the Commune to the key personnel of the Commune's administration, as public servants, magistrates and judges, became 'elective, responsible and revocable'.[33] It is arguable that this was an emerging tendency within the Commune which would have become more prominent if the Commune had been able to survive its military trauma. Marx implies that these changes with regard to the judicial functionaries were to come in the future. Yet the reality of the activities of Rigault, Da Costa and Ferre in the police prefecture is very different from Marx's imagined democratic practice.[34]

The Commune was made distinctive by a further feature, for it was not a Parliamentary body by virtue of simultaneously combining executive and legislative functions. This theme is not developed, for Marx had little to report about the administrative habits of the new commissions, whose competence varied from the emphatic work of the Commissions of Labour and Exchange and Education to the vagaries of the Commissions for Foreign Affairs and the instrumental activities of the Police. Marx did attempt to reinforce his theme of the working class presence within the Commune by placing working-class men ahead of the acknowledged representatives, although a more realistic literal assessment would have reversed this order. He also stated that 'from the members of the Commune downwards public service had to be done at workman's wages'; this clearly was not accomplished even if a form of egalitarian-

[32] Benoît Malon, *La Troisième Défaite du Prolétariat Français* (Neuchâtel, 1871); Jacques Rougerie, 'Les Elections du 26 mars à la Commune de Paris. Histoire Economique, Sociale et Politique' (Paris, 1955) Diplôme d'Etudes Supérieures (University of Sussex); and Jacques Rougerie, 'Chapitre 4. La Ville, Les Elections du 26 Mars', *Paris Libre 1871* (Paris, 1971), pp. 135–46.

[33] 'The Civil War in France', p. 331.

[34] Patrick Hutton, *The Cult of the Revolutionary Tradition: the Blanquists in French Politics, 1864–1893* (London, 1981), Ch. IV, 'The Commune as Atheist Drama', pp. 59–99.

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ism existed within the Commune. Marx had also sought to democratize the Commune too intensely by extending democratic accountability into areas which were either ambiguous or not operative during the Commune's brief life. However, the Commune Programme clearly stated that the Commune's magistrates and 'officials of all classes' were accountable and revocable.[35] Marx was attempting to defend the Paris Commune in a hostile environment and he may have consciously chosen to inject an element of idealization into the debate. Engels was later to refer to the unconscious tendencies of the Commune which he said Marx had been justified in outlining in the circumstances of the construction of the address.[36] Certainly the new principle of democratic accountability had the potential for being extended to the judiciary, the police and the administration. Marx was also most likely aware of the necessity to answer those revolutionary socialists within the First International who favoured the total abolition of the state. In this context it was most important to demonstrate to those who were undecided on this matter that the state could be democratized and that the key instruments of the state, the police, the judges and magistrates and the administrators, could be made accountable to an elective body based on universal manhood suffrage.

One of the most innovatory features of the 19 April programme was that the independent Commune negated earlier forms of Jacobin centralism, especially those associated with the Red Terror of 1793–4. Centralization was defined in the programme as being by its very nature 'despotic, unintelligent, arbitrary and onerous'.[37] Instead the political unity of France would be restored through Republicanism and Federalism. Marx keeps clearly to the principles associated with the Commune, for 'Paris Libre' was to be a model for the large industrial cities, while in the French countryside communalism and federalism were to be introduced. Together they would regenerate France for 'the Communal Constitution would have restored to the social body all the forces hitherto absorbed by the State parasite feeding upon, and clogging the free movement of society'.[38]

In his concluding remarks in these passages of *The Civil War in France* Marx emphasized that the Commune would bring cheap government because it had destroyed the two great sources of state expenditure: the standing army and 'state functionarism'.[39] He also thought the Communal constitution would place the working class of the largest towns in a position of leadership *vis à vis* the peasantry. The Commune was not to be construed as a regression to an

[35] 'Declaration to the People', p. 82.

[36] *Collected Works*, Vol. 47, ed. V. Kunina and V. Pospelova (London, 1993), p. 74.

[37] 'Declaration to the People', p. 82.

[38] *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, p. 333. In Paul Thomas's opinion: 'The most positive feature of the Paris Commune, according to *The Civil War in France*, Marx's 1871 address on it, was that it radically deinstitutionalised political power, and in so doing repoliticized society at large.' Thomas, *Alien Politics*, p. 105.

[39] 'The Civil War in France', pp. 333–4.

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earlier medieval form of Commune, nor should it be seen as an attempt to create a federation of small states. Marx devoted considerable passages to the peasantry in the address and this emphasis flows from his desire for the city and the countryside to be properly integrated. This relationship was tied to the notion of working class ascendancy which was a theme flowing throughout *The Civil War in France*. Marx argued that the Commune was the first revolution in which the working class were openly acknowledged by the majority of the Parisian population as being able to make essential social initiatives. This leadership role was also replicated throughout France, where the working class of the large urban centres would be able to respond to the urgent needs of the peasantry. The Commune was a working-class government which was reliant upon broad class alliances but had the potentiality of being founded upon the support of the overwhelming majority of the people of France, who in Marx's opinion freely gave their assent to this working-class hegemony.

After these paragraphs Marx arrives at one of his crucial themes, the situation of the working class within the Paris Commune, for the 'true secret of the Commune' was that 'it was essentially a working class government, the product of the producing against the appropriating class, the political form at last discovered under which to work out the economic emancipation of labour'.[40] Marx stated that: 'The Commune was therefore to serve as a lever for uprooting the economic foundations upon which rest the existence of classes, and therefore class rule'.[41] In his opinion the Commune intended to abolish 'that form of property' which makes 'the labour of the many the wealth of the few'. It aimed at the expropriation of the expropriators'.[42] Just how these expropriations were to occur was not explained in *The Civil War in France*. It is clear that the revolutionary anarchist idea of expropriating the expropriators at the moment of the insurrection was rejected. However, like his Bakuninite opponents Marx argued that co-operative production would replace capitalist manufacturing and industrial production. It is at this point that the lack of information coming from Paris about associations might be said to impoverish Marx's narrative. However, associations had been discussed within the Paris sections of the First International between 1867 and 1871 and Marx was presumably aware of these debates.[43] An earlier wave of association activity had also occurred between 1847 and 1848 although these ventures were barely given any attention in his *Class Struggles in France 1848–1850*.[44] Marx would appear to have been only

[40] *Ibid.*, p. 334.

[41] *Ibid.*

[42] *Ibid.*

[43] J. Rougerie, 'Mil Huit Cent Soixante et Onze', *La Commune de 1871, Colloque de Paris (Mai 1971)* (Paris, 1972), pp. 50–77.

[44] For associations during the 1840s see Remi Gossez, *Les Ouvriers de Paris. Book One. L'Organisation, 1848–1851*. Bibliothèque de la Révolution de 1848, Vol. 24 (La Roche-sur-Yon, 1967); Alain Faure Jacques Rancière, *La Parole Ouvrière, 1830–1851*

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a tentative supporter of workers' associations. The crucial political conjuncture was the means by which the working class's political power would lead to an economic restructuring. In the address Marx adopted a vague hypothetical, even utopian, position by referring to 'united co-operative societies' regulating 'national production upon a common plan, thus taking it under their own control'.[45] No such plan was discussed by all the elected members of the Commune, although Leo Frankel, the chairman of the Commission of Labour and Exchange, in an article published on 18 March 1877 claimed that the workers' associations had produced a plan just before the Commune fell which organized production amongst the twenty arrondissements. These associations were to be closely co-ordinated and this would be initially mediated by the Commission of Labour and Exchange.[46] The passages in the *Critique of the Gotha Programme* (1875), that deal with the emancipation of labour do not deal specifically with the Communard experience and are both excessively abstracted and ambiguous.[47] *The Civil War* statements are highly problematical for would the freedom to negotiate and administer associations be sustained if control was ultimately invested in a national plan? Engels had referred in January 1873 to the Commune taking over shut-down factories and workshops and handing them over to workers' associations. Marx already knew of some of these activities when he was drafting *The Civil War in France*, for in the first draft he acknowledged that many workshops and 'manufacturies' had been closed because their owners had left Paris. He records that a Commune commission in co-operation with delegates chosen by the different trades was to inquire into this situation and was to work out ways in which these abandoned places of work could be handed over to co-operative workers' societies. This commission was to be responsible for the statistical information on the abandoned workshops and 'manufacturies.[48] The Commune, through the decree of 16 April on abandoned workshops, did initiate an inquiry through the trade

(Paris, 1976); William H. Sewell Jr., *Work and Revolution in France, The Language of Labor from the Old Regime to 1848* (Cambridge, 1980); and R. Magraw, *The Age of Artisan Revolution 1815–1871* (Oxford, 1992).

[45] 'The Civil War in France', pp. 334–5.

[46] Article by Leo Frankel in *Munkas Heti-Kronika* (Workers Weekly), 18 March 1877, text printed in *Europe* (April–May 1951), p. 180.

[47] K. Marx, 'Critique of the Gotha Programme', *Collected Works*, Vol. 24, ed. V. Smirnova (London, 1989), pp. 85–6, 93.

[48] F. Engels, 'The Housing Question', Part III, *Collected Works*, Vol. 23, ed. L. Golman (London, 1988), p. 370; and '. . . on April 16th it [the Commune] ordered a statistical tabulation of factories which had been closed down by the manufacturers, and the working out of plans for the operation of these factories by the workers formerly employed in them, who were to be organised in co-operative socities, and also plans for the organisation of these co-operatives in one grand union', F. Engels 'Introduction to K. Marx's *The Civil War in France* (1891)', *Collected Works*, Vol. 27, ed. B. Tartakovsky and V. Smirnova (London, 1990), p. 185.

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unions into the state of Parisian industry and manufacturing and sought where possible to encourage workers' associations. The trade unions were asked to prepare a statistical survey of abandoned workshops, and 'to present a report on the concrete measures to be taken for putting these workshops back into operation'. These workshops 'are now to be operated by co-operative associations of the workers who were employed in them'.[49] The trade unions were also to produce a constitution for these worker co-operatives. A jury of arbitration was to decide on the amount of compensation to be paid to the former owners and the conditions of cession. The inquiry was instructed to present its report to the Commission of Labour and Exchange which would draft the appropriate decree.[50] This commission's most sustained work was undertaken with the Union of Women For the Defence of Paris and Aid to the Wounded, which functioned as a city-wide organization. One can discern an emerging and influential trend within the Commune, mainly encouraged by the members of the First International, which did seek to encourage associations and alter market conditions.[51] Yet Marx's exposition of the process of economic emancipation of labour remains restricted. The intent is outlined but the account conspicuously lacks content. The material which had been referred to in the first draft was not included in the printed address. The situation became more complicated in 1872 when *The Civil War in France* and a new edition of the *Communist Manifesto* were both in circulation. *The Manifesto* was undoubtedly more statist in its statements on socialist and working class economic activity than *The Civil War in France*, for it refers to the state ownership of industries, labour armies and the centralization of credit through a state monopoly bank.[52] If Marx and Engels were aware of the contradictory positions between the co-operative associations emphasized in *The Civil War in France* and the statist forms of economic development expressed in *The Communist Manifesto*, then they chose to allow these ambiguities to continue. Yet this dichotomy was

[49] 'Decree on Co-operative Operation of Abandoned Workshops, 16 April 1871', ed. E. Schulkind, pp. 162–3.

[50] *Ibid.*

[51] Sources relevant to the association movement include 'A Stone Carver's Letter' and 'A Nail Maker's Letter', in *The Communards of Paris*, ed. Edwards, pp. 123–6; 'The Louvre Workshop Regulations', in *Journal Officiel* (3 May 1871); 'Decree of Co-operative Operation of Abdandoned Workshops' (16 April 1871), 'The Union of Tailors' (19th April 1871), 'The Union of Mechanics and Metal Workers' (25th April 1871), 'Workers in the Jewelry Trade' (7 May 1871), 'Foundry Worker's Letter', 'Letter of a Tailors' Association', 'Petition of Women Workers', 'Letter and Proposal from the Association of Women to the Commission of Labour and Exchange', in *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. Schulkind, pp. 162–8 and 175–80. The material on the Association of Women for the Defence of Paris and Aid to the Wounded is to be found in the Archives Historiques du Ministère de la Guerre (France), cartons collectifs AG Ly 22.

[52] Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, 'Manifesto of the Communist Party', *Collected Works*, Vol. 6, ed. L. Golman (London, 1976), p. 505.

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central to the socialist movement. No groups of Commune workers expressed an interest in the state ownership of industries and labour armies; and it would appear that Marx and Engels were more imbued with statist models of economic development (even envisaging state monopolies) than those sections of the Parisian working class which supported and cooperated with the Commission of Labour and Exchange.

The next two paragraphs of *The Civil War in France* (sixty-five and sixty-six), re-establish the centrality of the working class. Marx ascribes to them the collective wisdom of understanding that they will have 'to pass through long struggles, through a series of historic processes, transforming circumstances and men'.[53]

Although most of the analysis in this article has commented on the published text of *The Civil War in France* the first draft of the address is actually the longer piece of work. It is at times the more explicit text on matters of detail. It is also fragmentary with several areas of discontinuity, as for example when the heading 'Financial Affairs' is introduced with no subsequent narrative, or where the narrative breaks off in an arbitrary manner, as with the theme of the Paris of Cocottes and Cocodes.[54] Despite its loose structure this draft shows how Marx initially categorized the Commune's response to important matters like the Thiers's Governmental decrees on rents and commercial bills and the pay of the National Guard.[55] The first draft does not in any sense represent the hidden truths of the Commune which were subsequently left out in the printed address. The distinction between the two texts remains a matter of emphasis, as for instance in the lengthier passages given over to the Government of Defence, or the Comtist material.[56] The early pages are given over to General Trochu's strategy for capitulation and the sleazy activities of the leading figures in the National Government. Thiers's duplicity and callousness over the execution of Communard prisoners is exposed as Marx ranges over a twelve-page synopsis of the latter's career, dwelling on Thiers's scheming and intriguing and his contempt for the working class, as well as his long career in the Party of Order.[57] Marx traces out how the National Government misrepresented the Communards as 'convicts', merely a handful of 'desperados', in order to create 'a wall of lies' which would reinforce provincial passivity and prevent the larger provincial cities from rallying to the Commune.[58] In the passages which Marx ascribes to be the Commune's central characteristics there are a few features which do not occur in the final address, for example his brief exposition of how

[53] 'The Civil War in France', pp. 334–5.
[54] 'The First Draft', *Collected Works*, Vol. 22, pp. 473–4.
[55] *Ibid.*
[56] *Ibid.*, pp. 437–43, 445, 504–5.
[57] *Ibid.*, pp. 438, 441–3, 453–8, 428–30, 462–3.
[58] *Ibid.*, pp. 465–6.

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the Commune liberated the Parisian prostitutes.[59] Those measures which Marx refers to as 'mostly for the middle class' which relate to commercial bills and rent are primarily the concerns of the lower middle classes, to that very numerical stratum of self-employed artisans, the profusion of tradesmen, grocers, cafe owners and other small shop-keepers who lived and worked in Paris.[60] Several leading figures of the Commune including Jules Vallès stressed that the small businessman was the brother of the proletarian worker.[61] The class politics of the Commune unified the wage-earners with the self-employed artisans and the small shop-keepers against the élite sections of the haute bourgeoisie. In that sense much of the Commune's politics was popular and should not be perceived in reductive terms as merely a conflict between the working class and lower middle class. The themes associated with Marx's subdivisions of the 'general measures', the 'measures of public safety' and 'the character of the Commune', are similar to the passages which dealt with these themes in the address.[62] It is mostly a case of a slightly different wording with regard to the key themes of the parasitic state, the Communard state and 'the political form of social emancipation'. Marx insisted that 'the Commune does not [do] away with class struggles, through which the working classes strive to the abolition of all classes and, therefore, of all classes [class rule] because it does not represent a peculiar interest'.[63] In both texts Marx argued that the Commune represents 'the Liberation of Labour' and as such was implicitly socialist. For Marx 'it [the Commune] affords the rational medium in which class struggle can run through its different phases in the most rational and humane way'.[64] The themes on the 'Social Measures of the Commune' and decentralization are also similar to what was finally printed. The last passages of the First Draft consist of a detailed outline of the Vendome affair, a narrative which is supported by extracts from proclamations of the Central Committee of the National Guard. The issue is the legitimacy and illegitimacy of the activities of the supporters of the Party of Order in Paris. It is in these passages that Marx makes a criticism of the Central Committee for not having issued the order for their troops to immediately march on Versailles following the flight of Admiral Saisset, Thiers's commander of the National Guard, and the collapse of the Party of Order's support among the National Guard.[65] Marx was later to reiterate this criticism, yet he appears not to have considered the likely military

[59] *Ibid.*, p. 473.

[60] See the discussion on self-employed artisans, small businesses and Parisian manufacturing by Alain Cottereau, 'Denis Poulot's Le Sublime — a Preliminary Study', in *Voices of the People: The Social Life of 'La Sociale' at the End of the Second Empire*, ed. Adrian Rifkin and Roger Thomas (London, 1988), pp. 97–180.

[61] *Le Cri du Peuple* (22 March 1871).

[62] 'The First Draft', pp. 474–6, 476–9, 483–92.

[63] *Ibid.*, pp. 490–1.

[64] *Ibid.*

[65] *Ibid.*, pp. 507–14.

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intervention by the Prussian generals and troops if the National Government had been put to flight by the forces of the Parisian National Guard. The draft breaks off in the midst of an outline of Theirs' second assault on Paris which occurred on 2 April with the fighting between Courbevoie and Neuilly.[66]

The second draft is considerably shorter than the first draft and the final text, and is a less interesting piece of writing. The themes are similar to those of the printed address but in a more summarized form. The balance favours a stronger emphasis upon the Government of Defence, Thiers, the Rural Assembly and the Warfare. These themes are similar to those in Parts I, II and III of the address where Marx had sought to meet head-on the vituperations about the Commune coming from the members of the Versailles Government. His basic strategy was to diminish their credibility by showing how they were embroiled in financial scandals, fraud, political intrigue, and had a long lineage of opposition to democratic movements. Marx appeared to attribute great potential to the documents that were kept in the Bank of France for exposing Thiers's government. The later passages of *The Civil War in France* are concerned with the contentious matter of the Commune's treatment of hostages, the bombardment of the city, and the fires and widespread destruction of buildings.[67] Brooding over the whole situation was the malign presence of the Prussian armies and Bismarck's political adventurism.

Marx's *The Civil War in France* is not a complete history of the Paris Commune. It did not purport to be. Yet some of its omissions and silences are glaring. Even allowing for the withering away of source material in May 1871, Marx's decision to exclude the popular activities and the activities of the socialist feminists is problematical. The Commune's clubs had evolved from the public meetings of 1868–70 and those which had met during the siege of Paris by the Prussian armies from 1870 to 1871. Among the contemporary publications which described these meetings were J.B. Clément's *Le Club de la Redoute* (Paris, 1868), A.Vitu's *Les Réunions Publiques à Paris, 1868–9*, (Paris, 1869) and *Les Réunions Electorales à Paris (mai 1869)* (Paris, 1869), G.de Molinari's *Le Mouvement Socialiste et Les Réunions Publique avant La Révolution du 4th Septembre* (Paris, 1869) and his 'Les Socialisme en 1869. Discussion à La Redoute et Dans Les Autres Réunions Publiques', *Journal des Economistes* (Juin 1869), pp. 333–50.[68] There was a lengthy pedigree for these

[66] *Ibid.*, pp. 512–14.

[67] 'The Civil War in France', pp. 346–55.

[68] Geoffrey de Molinari, *Les Clubs Rouges Pendant Le Siège de Paris* (Paris, 1871), 15 March 1871. Molinari gives particular prominence to the Club Favi in Belleville and the Club de La Reine-Blanche, Montmartre. He summarizes the debates at twenty-two clubs. The introduction to this book, 'Les Clubs, Historie, Organisation, Physionomie', was published in the *Revue des Deux Mondes* (5 December 1870).

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clubs, some of whose histories can be outlined.[69] A well-informed political commentator ought to have been conversant with these events. Several Parisian papers, including *Le Rappel* and *La Marseillaise*, published accounts of these meetings. Other newspapers followed the meetings in a particular arrondissement, as was the case with the Bonapartist newspaper *Le Pays* which reported on the happenings of the clubs in the eighteenth arrondissement.[70] More puzzling still is the lack of any kind of reference to the public meetings held by the thirty-two Paris sections of the First International which were regularly advertised in Communard newspapers including *La Sociale*, *Le Cri du Peuple*, *Journal Officiel*, *Le Vengeur*, *La Commune*, *Le Réveil*, *Paris Libre*, and *La Révolution Sociale et Politique*.[71] Do these silences signify that Marx had certain inhibitions and reservations about popular working-class politics? He probably shared the elected Commune's reticence when confronted by explicit expressions of popular politics. Popular sovereignty in this form was not enthusiastically supported by Marx. The workers who are mentioned in letters and public statements of the 1870s remain sensible, noble, heroic and virtuous, they also exist only as an abstraction, in an idealized rhetorical form. The reality of popular politics as expressed in the Commune in all probability was an embarrassment to Marx, who for politically pragmatic reasons chose to mediate their role in the Commune by imposing exclusion. It could be argued that since the clubs were full of speakers who were anti-clerical, and who at times invoked the guillotine and red terror, Marx was simply recognizing the obvious: no defence of the Commune could defend invocations which appeared to confirm the reports coming from Versailles about the 'Reds'. Yet it is also appropriate to suggest that Marx did favour a form of statist politics rather than the looser associations of popular movements. Perhaps it is unreasonable to have expected Marx to have been able to respond to the politics of neighbourhood, the streets, the cafe and the barricade. But the locality and the immediacy of its politics was at the heart of Communard politics. The Federation des Clubs which emerged around the churches of St Eustace (first arrondissement), St Ambroise (eleventh arrondissement) and St Nicholas-des-Champs (third arrondissement)

[69] A modern study is Alain Dalotel, Alain Faure, Jean Claude-Freirmuth, *Aux Origines de La Commune* (Paris, 1980).

[70] Robert Wolfe, 'The Parisian Club de La Revolution of the 18th Arrondissement 1870–1871', *Past and Present*, No. 39 (1968), pp. 81–119.

[71] Thirty-two Communard clubs are named by Jean Bruhat, Jean Dautry, Emile Tersen, *La Commune de 1871* (Paris, 1960; 2nd edn., 1970), 'Cartes des Clubs et sections de L'Internationale', pp. 164–5. There is a detailed article on the clubs by Eugene Schulkind, 'The Activity of Popular Organizations During the Paris Commune of 1871', *French Historical Studies*, Vol. 1, No. 4 (1960), pp. 394–415. Some minutes and miscellaneous club papers have survived and are kept at the Archives Historiques de La Guerre, cartons collectifs, C–22.

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was an important expression of popular politics.[72] These clubs were given insufficient attention by most elected Commune members, who failed to mobilize them and who were unable to delegate political powers to the clubs. Thus the traditional dichotomy between electoral representation and popular sovereignty remained in the Commune. This disjuncture was preserved in the text of *The Civil War in France* where their absence creates the suspicion that Marx was inclined towards statist structure and managerial politics.

The absence of material on the activities of the women's clubs and the Union might be explained circumstantially with the suggestion that the information never came through from Paris. Yet some of these meetings had occurred before the start of May, and presumably Marx was able to read the article in the *Times* of 6 May which purported to describe in detail a women's club meeting on the Boulevard d'Italie before he completed the final draft. Those who seek to sustain the theme of Marx's sensitivity to women can point to the speech delivered by Marx on 19 September 1871 at the London conference of the International when he proposed that women be allowed to affiliate to the International and to form their own associations.[73] A more fundamental criticism is that Marx's concept of the working class, like so many of his socialist contemporaries, was gendered, rooted in a form of economism which expected engineers to have more advanced socialist attitudes than the women who worked in workshops as artificial flower makers or those who washed dirty clothes.[74] Marx was familiar with and encouraged the intellectual capacity and reading habits of his own daughters, but it would appear that he had rather limited attitudes towards the forms of socialist feminism that were emerging in Paris in April and May 1871, for the largest popular organization which existed in Paris, the Union, did not receive even the most oblique reference in *The Civil War*. Was the blockade on source material so finite that nothing could be said, could Marx find nothing appropriate from Elizabeth Dmetrieff's letter addressed to Mr Jung? One remains sceptical that Marx was as responsive as Leo Frankel, who sustained a supportive role with the secretariat of the Union. *The Communist Manifesto* had stated that Communists were 'the most advanced and resolute section of the working-class parties' . . . 'that section which pushes

[72] Eleven clubs were affiliated to this federation. *Le Vengeur* records: 'This is a most urgent and most useful measure; it is indispensable for public meetings to federate in such a way that each may propose and if possible adopt resolutions already voted by the others, in order to exercise a legitimate influence in public opinion.' Resolution of 4 May, Salle Molière, 159 Rue Saint Martin.

[73] Speech by Marx at the London Conference of the International, 19 September 1871, *Karl Marx and Friedrick Engels Writings on the Paris Commune*, ed. H. Draper, p. 224.

[74] For Marx's attitudes to women wage earners see Harold Benson, 'Victorian Sexual Ideology and Marx's Theory of the Working Class', *International Labor and Working Class History*, No. 25 (Spring 1984), pp. 1–23; and *ibid.*, No. 26, pp. 45–52.

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forward all others' . . . 'they have over the great mass of the proletariat the advantage of clearly understanding the line of march, the conditions, and ultimate general results of the proletarian movement'.[75] But what role were women to play in this march? Marx had barely referred to them in the *Class Struggles in France* and a similar reticence appeared in *The Civil War in France*. The circumstantial evidence would appear to be conclusive. Marx appeared to be only able to respond to the role of women in the Commune after its demise. The construct of the working class in *The Civil War in France* remains an idealized form of collective activity and it is overwhelmingly male. In September a possibly contrite Marx referred to the great role women played in life, in the factories, in taking part in strikes and in the Commune. He added that women have more fervour than men. The minutes then record 'that he added a few words to recall the fervent participation of the women in Paris'.[76] Just what was entailed in that fervour has been recently sketched out in a series of articles on women in the Commune by Eugene Schulkind, Kathleen Jones and Françoise Vèrges, David Shafer and Martin Phillip Johnson.[77] Although Marx and Engels did modify *The Communist Manifesto* in the context of the Communard experience they restricted this to the matter of the machinery of the state; nothing was added to draw attention to the socialist feminist activities during the Paris Commune.

Certain other omissions are much more understandable. Any reference to the anti-clericalism and the rich language of some of the club speakers, or the atheist beliefs of leading Blanquists would surely have inflamed the situation in London, where there was an overwhelmingly hostile press. Some forms of red terrorism did exist amongst the elected members of the Paris Commune, for Rigault and Ferre were determined advocates of authoritative rule and were highly interested in police officers, former spies and espionage work.[78] Similarly, virtually all the surviving descriptions of club meetings, or the summaries of club debates, record abusive speeches directed against priests, monks and nuns. Of course there were many other themes amongst the speeches, including statements expressing concern over the city's food supplies as well as calls for free public education. Renan's *Life of Christ* was even commended by Citizen

[75] 'Manifesto of the Communist Party', p. 497.

[76] Minutes of the First International, 29 September 1871, *Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels Writings on the Paris Commune*, ed. Draper, p. 224.

[77] Schulkind, 'Socialist Women During the 1871 Paris Commune', pp. 124–63; Kathleen Jones and François Vèrges, 'Aux Citoyennes! Women, Politics and the Paris Commune of 1871', *History of European Ideas*, Vol. 13, No. 6 (1991), pp. 711–32; David A. Shafer, 'Plus Que des Ambulancières: Women in Articulation and Defence of Their Ideals During the Paris Commune (1871)', *French History*, Vol. 7, No. 1 (1993), pp. 85–101; Phillip Martin Johnson, 'Citizenship and Gender: The Légion des Fédérées in the Paris Commune of 1871', *French History*, Vol. 8, No. 3 (1994), pp. 276–95.

[78] Hutton, *The Cult of the Revolutionary Tradition*, pp. 65–86.

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Demar at the Club Ambroise on 9 May.[79] The content of the speeches in the clubs was highly varied but it did contain material that could be readily sensationalized. As the war situation deteriorated in May and news of the Versailles government's brutal treatment of Communard prisoners filtered through, the tenor of the club debates became more constrained and bitter. Marx was keenly aware of the dangers of even referring to these affairs and chose to leave them out. He chose instead to invoke a form of idealism with regard to both the dynamics of the Commune and the Parisian working class, a characteristic which he knew to be untrue when applied *en masse* to the elected representatives, let alone the Commune's working class supporters. He was not prepared to defend the Paris Commune unconditionally, nor was he prepared to offer a terrain which might in any way appear to confirm the more sensational reporting of the events in Paris. This judicious editing meant that the view he offered of the Commune in *The Civil War* was unrepresentative. The Communard experience was much more varied than Marx allows.

The Commune's very existence, which was so significant for Marx, was a source of disquiet for the revolutionary socialists in Italy and the Jura Federation. Kropotkin and his anarcho-communist allies subsequently regarded the Commune as primarily a popular entity. Within this anarchist historiography the Commune lost its revolutionary impetus once elections were held, and it subsided into a parliamentary regime. Kropotkin wanted to represent the Commune primarily as an idea, a popular ideal which had international dimensions: 'It was made by the people themselves, it sprang spontaneously from the midst of the mass, and it was among the great masses of the people that it found its defenders, its heroes and its martyrs.'[80] Marx's thesis of a democratic statist and proletarian movement as outlined in *The Civil War in France* was clearly rejected. Kropotkin was adamant that: 'They tried to consolidate the Commune first, and defer the social revolution until afterwards, whereas the only way to go about it was to consolidate the Commune by means of the Social revolution.'[81] Marx and Kropotkin both thought the Commune was not a communist regime, although Kropotkin in 1891 represented Communard socialism as that form of socialism which was patronized by the middle classes for

> . . . the Commune was not Communist. She had not risen to the idea that everyone had the right to live, to have food and shelter. And she was not Anarchist enough to understand that the only salvation of the great city was in the popular initiative.[82]

[79] 'Declaration to the People', p. 101.
[80] *La Revolté* (20 March 1880).
[81] *Ibid.* Incorporated in *Paroles d'Une Revolté* (Paris, 1885).
[82] *Freedom* (April 1891).

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By 1891 Kropotkin was merely using the Paris Commune as a historical symbol in which to assert the validity of anarcho communist ideals.[83] The anarchist movement of the 1880s ought to be differentiated from the earlier response of those who were sympathetic to Bakunin's position in the First International, and those who were unable to support Marx's organizational strategies in the general council. The latter included prominent Communards including Benôit Malon, Léodile Champsieux (André Leo), Paule Minck, Gustave Lefrançais, Paul Brousse and Louis-Jean Pindy. Bakunin had implicitly rejected Marx's representation of the Paris Commune in his book *Statism and Anarchy* (1873).

> This means that no state, however democratic its forms, not even the reddest political republic — a people's republic only in the sense of the lie known as popular representation — is capable of giving the people what they need: the free organization of their own interests from below upward, without any interference, tutelage, or coercion from above. That is because no state, not even the most republican and democratic, not even the pseudo-popular state contemplated by Marx, in essence represents anything but the government of the masses from above downward, by an educated and thereby privileged minority which supposedly understands the real interests of the people better than the people themselves.[84]

During the course of 1872 Marx's support in the General Council began to ebb away. None of the English trade unionists who went to the Hague conference would support him, while his earlier close confidant, Seraillier, found himself during the summer of 1872 voting against the Marx 'family' and his Blanquist allies on the General Council. Marx and Engels were forced into several convoluted manoeuvres in the effort to purge Bakunin and his supporters from the First International. This acrimonious and disastrous struggle led to Marx's decision to work with the six Blanquists who had joined the general council. Backed by the Commune Révolutionnaire, which had between fifty to sixty members, Vaillant joined Marx in insisting that the powers of the General Council were strengthened, thereby intensifying the debate over the nature of the leadership inside the First International and compounding the internal disorganization and sectarianism.[85] The six Blanquists operated as a disciplined caucus and supported Marx's defence of the concept of working-class politics against those who preferred 'abstentionism'. Once Marx and Engels had achieved the expulsion of Bakunin and his allies and those opposed to the

[83] Caroline Cahm, *Kropotkin and the Rise of Revolutionary Anarchism* (Cambridge, 1989), pp. 28–31.

[84] *Bakunin Statism and Anarchy*, ed. Marshall S. Shatz (Cambridge, 1990), p. 24.

[85] For these themes see the informative thesis by Paul Martinez, 'Paris Communard Refugees in Britain, 1871–1880' (PhD thesis, University of Sussex, 1981); and P. Martinez, 'Amis Eprouvés et Sûrs: Les Réfugiés Blanquistes en Angleterre 1871–1879', *Blanqui et Blanquistes*, Societé d'Histoire de La Révolution de 1848 et des Révolutions du XIX Siecle (Paris, 1986), pp. 153–72.

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General Council, Marx immediately manoeuvred to break the alliance with the Blanquists. Veering away from the Blanquists' voluntarist analysis of the political situation in France, Marx and Engels reversed their earlier opposition to the proposal to move the General Council out of London and instead proposed that the General Council should be moved to New York. Feeling victimized by this duplicity the Blanquists then withdrew from the First International. This fractious struggle with the Blanquists had profound repercussions on what Marx and Engels subsequently said or wrote about the Paris Commune. Despite the initial work for the refugees the relations with the Communard exiles in London had been a disillusioning experience for Marx and Engels. They had not allowed the Section France de 1871 to join the General Council at the 23 September conference, seeing it as a vehicle for Landick, Roullier and worse still, the Jura Federation. Marx was also bitterly opposed to Vermersch's politics and harshly criticized Vesinier for his activities in London and during the Commune. Most of the Communard refugees in London had looked to the General Council for support and assistance. The reality of the liaison was deeply disillusioning for both sides.[86] Marx and Engels had steadily become alienated from all forms of French socialism; moreover, Marx had always been deeply polemical with Proudhon and his supporters.[87] The collapse of the First International and the destruction of the Commune had led to a further waning of Marx's and Engels' influence in France which was compounded by their quarrel with the Blanquists between 1872 and 1874. The letter written to F. Domela-Nieuwenhuis in 1881 is not a distillation of aged wisdom; the comments on the Paris Commune are merely an intemperate aside rooted in the broken hopes and political sacrifices of 1871–2.

After 1872 Engels subsequently made more comments on the Commune than Marx. In the main they consist of a series of brief commemorative statements invoking in an idealized manner aspects of the Commune and Parisian working class, a few asides which display appropriate insight, as with 'The Housing Question' (January 1873), and some attempts to claim some kind of lineage with the Commune which 'was the child of the International intellectually'.[88] He sustained this form of association in a letter written on 1 January 1884 in response to Bernstein's inquiry over the passage taken from *The Civil War in France* and placed in *The Communist Manifesto*. In this letter Engels stated 'that in *The Civil War* the unconscious tendencies of the Commune were put down to its credit as more or less conscious plans was justified and even

[86] Martinez, 'Paris Communard Refugees in Britain'; Martinez, 'Amis Eprouvés et Sûrs', pp. 158–68; and Paul Thomas, *K. Marx and the Anarchists* (London, 1980), pp. 327–9.

[87] This theme is outlined in Thomas, *K. Marx and the Anarchists*.

[88] F. Engels, 'The Housing Question, part III', *Collected Works*, Vol. 23, p. 370, F. Engels letter to F. Sorge (12–17 September 1874), *Collected Works*, Vol. 45, ed. V. Kunina and V. Pospelova (London, 1993), p. 41.

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necessary under the circumstances'.[89] His most substantive essay on the Paris Commune was the introduction to new editions of the Two Addresses of the General Council on the Franco-Prussian War and Marx's *The Civil War in France*. Engels's essay was dated 'London, on the twentieth anniversary of the Paris Commune, March 18th, 1891'.[90] In this essay Engels writes:

> If today, after twenty years, we look back at the activity and historical significance of the Paris Commune of 1871, we shall find it necessary to make a few additions to the account given in *The Civil War in France*.[91]

In the remaining one hundred and sixty lines of the essay Engels returns to familiar territory. He resurrects the Proudhonists to a role they never played in the Commune, making them responsible for the Commune's economic decrees. These decrees were actually strongly mediated by the Paris Sections of the First International, which in 1871 had a negligible Proudhonist presence. Proudhon and the Proudhonists were implanted into this Communard material because Engels wished to situate them as a regressive, outmoded stratum. In this caricature Proudhon appears as the socialist of the peasant and master craftsman, a man who apparently hated associations. Having victimized his ideological enemy Engels then gives an exaggerated synopsis of the role of large-scale industry, failing to realize that the putting-out systems and forms of contracted labour employed by the Parisian department stores were larger economic associations than any of the large industrial premises favoured by himself, presumably the railway workshops in Batignolles, or the Cail engineering factories built in Paris. The essentialist theme that Engels wants to instil into his readership is that 'the Commune was the grave of the Proudhon school of socialism'.[92] He then follows up this prejudiced analysis by stating that 'the Blanquists fared no better'. This assessment is consistent with the themes Engels had brought to his earlier bitter commentary on Blanquism in the article 'The Programme of the Blanquist Refugees of the Commune', which was published on 26 June 1874.[93] This essay is a legacy of the mutual estrangement between the Blanquists and Marx and Engels at the Hague Conference. Blanquism is situated in the regressive political context of the reign of Louis Philippe, and so an emergent movement of the late 1860s is subsumed into the pre–1848 era of conspiratorial intrigue. According to Engels the Blanquists are archaic because of their adherence to a form of Putschism. He places a strong emphasis on their insistence upon personal dictatorship. The elderly Blanqui

[89] Letter by Engels to E. Bernstein (1 January 1884), *Collected Works*, Vol. 47, pp. 73–4.

[90] *Collected Works*, Vol. 27, p. 191.

[91] F. Engels, 'Introduction (1891)', *Collected Works*, Vol. 27, p. 187.

[92] *Ibid.*, p. 188.

[93] Extracts from Engels' 'The Programme of the Blanquist Commune Refugees' are printed in *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. Schulkind, pp. 239–40, and *Karl Marx and Friedrick Engels Writings on the Paris Commune*, ed. Draper, pp. 227–30.

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remains a revolutionary of the previous generation, while the London Blanquists have all apparently fallen 'prey to all the self-deception of emigration'. Somewhat surprisingly Engels, in view of his own aversion to Vermersch, invokes this author to ridicule the Blanquists, who are described as 'rascals or accomplices of rascals'. Blanquism is thus caricatured as excessively secretive, they are all 'cloak and dagger' characters. In this portrait Engels appears to echo Marx's famous characterization of professional conspirators in his review written in March and April 1850 of A. Chanu's *Les Conspirateurs* and L. de La Hodde's *La Naissance de La République en Fevrier 1848*.[94] Having chastized this socialist movement Engels then introduced the theme that the Blanquists did not understand social theory. However, the London Blanquists' real offence is ironically their declaration that the Commune was sacred and infallible. Although Marx and Engels had been clearly aware of the evocative power of the Commune as a political symbol, for they had reiterated this theme in several commemorative speeches during 1871–3, by June 1874 they were keen to demonstrate the fallibility and flaws of French socialism. Engels concludes his review by making some ironical comments on the Blanquists' interest in terrorism. His final assessment was that they are something of a joke, inconsequential people aping history, whose programme is in reality an exercise in juvenility. Several Marxist writers have treated this polemical piece in a deferential manner, seeking to represent the commentary as a shrewd evaluation of the political capacity of Blanquism. However, the writings of Tridon on Herbertism and Christianity cannot be dismissed as mere juvenility, nor should the essay 'Instructions for an Uprising' in Haussmann's Paris be relegated to the dustbin of history. Since Blanquism had been renewed during the late 1860s by an influx of young students Engels twisted their youthfulness in an ageist manner by stating that the movement was only represented by juvenility.[95] Yet Blanquism was profoundly popular amongst certain sections of the Parisian working class because it was staunchly historicist, looking to the Great French Revolution of 1789–94 for its revolutionary theorizing. Its firm commitment to republicanism and anti-clericalism gave it a wider electoral base in the Communard elections than any candidates promoted by the Paris sections of the First International.[96] Engels' commentary on the Blanquist 1874 programme is merely a continuation of the sectarian struggles with rival socialist groupings and Communard refugees which led to the disintegration of the First Interna-

[94] Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Collected Works*, Vol. 10, ed. V. Kunina and V. Pospelova (London, 1978), pp. 311–25.

[95] Gustave Tridon, *Les Herbertistes* (Paris, 1871); Gustave Tridon, *Du Molochisme Juif: Etudes Critiques et Philosophiques* (Brussels, 1884); 'Instructions Pour un Prise d'Armes', Futur Anterieur, Editions de La Tête de Feuilles (Paris, 1972); Hutton, *The Cult of the Revolutionary Tradition*, pp. 38–58.

[96] Jacques Rougerie, 'Les Elections du 26 Mars à La Commune de Paris' (Paris, 1955), Diplome Etudes Supérieures.

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tional.[97] However, when he came to write the new introduction in 1891 Engels knew that Blanquism was a dissipated movement and that the Marxist social democratic parties in Germany and France were steadily growing in influence and prestige. His condemnation of Blanquism as an obsolescent movement was to be a much more plausible argument than it had been in 1874. The themes of the later essay appear to have been taken from the earlier commentary. According to Engels the Blanquists elected to the Commune and their adherents in the clubs were socialist only in instinct. Their interest in politics is twisted so that like the Proudhonists they remain economically naïve. Engels then drags in the old clichéd story about the Bank of France, to which Marx often referred, to blight both camps. In the fourth paragraph of these passages Engels returns to his criticism that the Blanquists were too absorbed by their ethos of strict discipline; their desire was to use state power to energize the people and to centralize all powers in the hands of a new revolutionary government. The Blanquists are thus set at odds with Marx's portrait of the new democratic workers' state. The final passages of Engels' essay are concerned with outlining in summary form the substantive statist themes which Marx outlined in *The Civil War in France*. His prose constructs are every bit as loyalist to Marx as his voting habits during the desperate last days of the First International.

Engels chose to finish his essay with a rhetorical flourish. He denounces 'the Social-Democratic' who is filled with 'wholesome terror at the words: Dictatorship of the Proletariat'. There then comes the famous statement: 'Well and good, gentlemen, do you want to know what this dictatorship looks like? Look at the Paris Commune. That was the Dictatorship of the Proletariat'.[98]
This final remark in his weightiest commentary on the Paris Commune has created a lengthy and somewhat introverted Communist historiography. Some Marxists saw nothing problematic in this since the Soviet experience and the cult of Lenin enhanced the status of Engels' phrasing and final evaluation. Since Lenin had been instrumental in reviving the interest in Marx's *The Civil War in France* through his preparatory research and writing in Switzerland during January and February 1917 for his own book, *State and Revolution*, Bolshevism and the Paris Commune experience mediated by Karl Marx could be represented as having a strong degree of continuity.[99] At the beginning of the earlier

[97] Engels' irritation with the Communard refugees is well caught in the following extract from his letter to F.A. Sorge, 12–17 September (London, 1874): 'The French refugees are in utter chaos. They have all fallen out with each other and with everyone else for quite personal reasons, money matters for the most part, and are now almost entirely rid of them . . . All these people have been horridly demoralised by their dissolute life during the war, the Commune, and in exhile, and the situation really has to be desperate to rescue a Frenchman once he has let himself go.' *Collected Works*, Vol. 45, p. 44.

[98] *Collected Works*, Vol. 27, p. 191.

[99] Marian Sawer, 'The Genesis of *State and Revolution*', *Socialist Register* (1977), pp. 209–27; and Marian Sawer, 'The Soviet Image of the Commune: Lenin and Beyond', *Images of the Commune*, ed. Leith, pp. 245–64.

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blue notebook written in Zurich Lenin was using Marx's *Eighteenth Brumaire* to highlight the state machine and to endorse Marx's 1852 themes of 'demolition' and 'breaking up' and the 1871 perspective of 'smashing' the existing state machinery.[100] However, Marxist-Leninism also offered the opportunity for making the Commune a decisively inferior event to the Soviet Revolution. Lenin and Trotsky took up highly polemical attitudes towards Kautsky, the influential Marxian theorist of German social democracy who had argued, in *Terror and Communism* (1920), that the Paris Commune was a superior electoral and governmental model to the Bolshevik regime.[101] Trotsky in particular was especially dismissive of the military difficulties of the Communards.[102] More recently a resolution endorsed by The Fourth International stated: 'The concept of the dictatorship of the proletariat . . . is a basic part of the Marxist theory of the state, of the proletarian revolution, and of the process toward building a classless society.'[103] West-European Marxists, however, have moved in a different direction and have sought to remove Marx from the stigma of Stalinism and to reconstitute him as a democratic figure. In this tradition the term 'the dictatorship of the proletariat' is seen as an unfamiliar term which was infrequently used by Marx. It is suggested that the wording was only popularized by Lenin, Trotsky, Stalin and Mao Tse-tung.[104] Since the abandonment of the term became part of an intense political debate within the communist parties in Italy, France, Spain and Britain, during the mid 1970s some writers, and in particular Monty Johnson, have subjected the phrase to a thorough piece of historiographical research.[105] The conclusion this writer drew from his careful scrutiny of Marx's writings is that the latter did not use the term directly with regard to the Commune, although there is an implicit association between what he, Marx, understood to be the meaning of this term and

[100] Sawer, 'The Genesis of *State and Revolution*', p. 217.

[101] Karl Kautsky, 'The Dictatorship of the Proletariat', in *The Paris Commune of 1871*, ed. Schulkind, pp. 282–4; and Karl Kautsky, *Terror and Communism* (London, 1920), Ch. VI, 'The Second Paris Commune', pp. 53–120.

[102] Leon Trotsky, *The Defence of Terrorism* (London, 1925).

[103] 'Resolution of the United Secretariat of the Fourth International: Social Democracy and the Dictatorship of the Proletariat', *Inprecor* (7 July 1977).

[104] Sawer, 'The Genesis of *State and Revolution*'; Sawer, 'The Soviet Image of the Commune'; Maurice Meisner, 'Images of the Paris Commune in Contemporary Chinese Thought', in *Revolution and Reaction: The Paris Commune 1871*, ed. John Hicks and Robert Tucker (Massachusetts, 1973), pp. 112–30; also John Bryan Starr, 'The Commune in Chinese Communist Thought', in *Images of the Commune*, ed. Leith, pp. 291–312.

[105] Johnstone, 'The Commune and Marx's Conception of the Dictatorship of the Proletariat', in *Images of the Commune*, ed. Leith, pp. 201–24. Also see Etienne Balibar, *Sur La Dictature du Proletariat* (Paris, 1976); P.J. Kain, 'Estrangement and the Dictatorship of the Proletariat', *Political Theory*, Vol. 7, No. 4 (1979), pp. 509–20; and Eric Chester, 'Revolutionary Socialism and the Dictatorship of the Proletariat', *Critique*, No. 17 (1986), pp. 83–9.

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what Marx represented as having occurred with regard to the workers' state created by the Paris Commune. Marx and Engels in this reading are in close agreement while Marx's statements on the Paris Commune remain profoundly consistent. However, the theme of Marx's intellectual consistency has faded in more recent years. His work is more frequently conceptualized as being discursive and at times inconsistent. Within this kind of reading *The Civil War in France* represents a more advanced and stronger commitment to the Paris Commune because it was written in the specific circumstances of April and May 1871. The subsequent happenings in London led Marx and Engels to have a jaundiced view of the Communard refugees. Consequently the comments from 1872 onwards by Marx and Engels seek to devalue the socialist activities within the Commune. Engels in particular adopted a polemical attitude towards a faction who were never active in the Commune, the Proudhonists, and a faction who were, the Blanquists. The activities of the Parisian branches of the First International on the Commission of Labour and Exchange and the efforts of the Union of Women to create work during the Commune were never directly referred to. Moreover, it is appropriate to conclude that *The Civil War in France* has an over-emphatic pre-occupation with the state. This emphasis appeared partly because of the limitations of Marx's source material, but it is also indicative of his own reticence about several of the more libertarian forms of French socialism. The associations, the popular clubs and the neighbourhoods, all explicit manifestations of popular sovereignty, are not given the presence or status to challenge the ascendancy of the theme of the workers' state. Because of these kinds of absences *The Civil War in France* remains only a partial defence of the Commune and a limited synopsis of Communard activities.

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